



**ARLINGTON COUNTY, VIRGINIA
OFFICE OF THE COUNTY BOARD**

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**CLERK TO THE
COUNTY BOARD**

MASON KUSHNIR

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February 21, 2026

Dear Chair Lucas, Chair R. Creigh Deeds, and Members of the Committees:

The Arlington County Board writes in strong support of the proposed budget amendment to increase funding for Specially Adapted Resource Clubs (SPARC) in Item 300, Paragraph S of the 2026–2028 Biennial Budget, carried by Senator Boysko.

Virginia remains under federal court supervision pursuant to the Permanent Injunction entered in *United States v. Virginia*, which requires the Commonwealth to provide services to individuals with developmental disabilities in the most integrated setting appropriate, consistent with the Americans with Disabilities Act and *Olmstead v. L.C.*

Compliance is not theoretical. It is measured in whether real people are living connected and dignified lives in their communities. At SPARC's Arlington center, that compliance has a name and a story:

- Like Jack, a non-speaking adult who communicates using an AAC device alongside his DSP of fifteen years. At SPARC, Jack chooses his activities each day — art, games, community walks — exercising independent decision-making in a structured, integrated setting. His participation reflects exactly what the ADA's integration mandate envisions: meaningful access to community life, not passive supervision.
- Like Audrey, one of the youngest participants, who entered SPARC facing significant emotional and sensory challenges. Through structured art therapy and adaptive sensory programming, she is developing emotional regulation, confidence, and social connection in community-based settings. Without this type of individualized day support, many adults like Audrey face isolation or regression — outcomes the Permanent Injunction is designed to prevent.
- Like Tom, a 42-year-old man on the autism spectrum who works part-time but lacks the endurance and social stability to maintain full employment. In traditional settings, Tom's anxiety is misunderstood. At SPARC, he finds structured peer engagement without stigma — a place to build resilience, routine, and authentic community inclusion.



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These are not anecdotal successes. They are measurable examples of integrated day service delivery for individuals with complex needs — precisely the population the Court has identified as underserved.

The proposed amendment does two critical things:

1. It increases funding to reflect the true cost of sustaining SPARC's integrated, participant-directed model.
2. It directs DBHDS to include SPARC participant data in reporting under the Permanent Injunction, ensuring that the Commonwealth receives compliance credit for services it is already delivering.

SPARC delivers this model at approximately \$15,900 per participant annually — substantially lower than the estimated \$58,000 per participant cost under provider-directed Medicaid day services. The amendment therefore advances civil rights compliance while remaining fiscally responsible.

The Permanent Injunction requires the Commonwealth to demonstrate measurable increases in integrated day participation and to collect data on individuals with complex medical and adaptive needs. Programs like SPARC are not supplemental — they are central to meeting those obligations. Behind every compliance term is a person like Jack choosing his day, Audrey finding her emotional footing, or Tom experiencing authentic social belonging.

For these reasons, we respectfully urge inclusion of this amendment in the final budget. Sustaining SPARC is both a civil rights obligation and a sound public investment.

Thank you for your continued leadership in advancing dignity, inclusion, and community integration for all Virginians.

Sincerely,

Matt de Ferranti
Chair, Arlington County Board